opportunity to considerably expand its footprint in Sri Lanka. China had not only provided fighter jets to the Sri Lankan army, it had also trained the pilots with the help of Islamabad.

Avinash said: 'When we warned the India foreign service about the Chinese, a senior officer told me not to worry. Let the China build the roads, he said, and we will ply our buses on those roads. When we complained about him, he was immediately removed and shifted to some insignificant position at the Delhi headquarters.'

The officer codenamed 'PAS' was fond of scotch and the Indian spies had reported on various occasions that he was more interested in attending high-spirit parties than protecting and preserving India's interests in Sri Lanka. 'Once he was trapped by our spies and subsequently confronted with the evidence, we wanted him out of Sri Lanka. He was a compromised man,' Avinash said, quoting a report that the R&AW had ciphered to New Delhi.

In January 2012, the then foreign minister, S.M. Krishna, landed in Colombo to strengthen ties with Sri Lanka and announce enhanced cooperation as a counterweight to China. He also handed over the first lot of housing units at Ariyalai and Jaffna and visited Galle in southern Sri Lanka where he inaugurated a segment of the Southern Railway Project implemented under the Line of Credit extended by India. But it was too late. The Chinese had already started massive operations in Sri Lanka.

LTTE 2:0?

What will emerge from the ashes in Jaffna? The regrouping of the LTTE and a renewed uprising against the Sri Lankan government? The spies who have been monitoring the situation